

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

CFO-ORC FILE # 1997-51

ACCEPTED 6-1

NEW STATE RECORD ☐

UNUSUAL RECORD ☒

Please print or type. Attach photographs and additional pages if necessary.

Species: Lesser Nighthawk | Chordeiles acutipennis
(Vernacular Name) (Scientific Name)

Date(s): 10 Sept. '95

Number of birds seen: 1 Sex: ♂ (?) Plumage: adult?

Locality: e of Poudre R. just s of Prospect ("Wren Site") Elevation: 5000'

Nearest town: Fort Collins County: Larimer

Time(s) observed: ~ 2 PM

Duration of observation (e.g. 1 sec., 5 min., etc.): 30 seconds to a minute

Other observers who saw the bird with you (give names, addresses, telephone numbers):

David Ely 4501 E Broadwalk [970/225-1047]
Fort Collins 80525

Other observers who saw the bird independently (give names, addresses, telephone numbers)

None that I know of

Light conditions (position of bird to light and shade, direction and strength of light):

Bird was above and then to the south of us, light from the south

Optical equipment used (e.g. power, types): 7x50 Nikon binocular

Distance, and how measured: 100' up

If photographed, type of equipment and film: —

Who else photographed the bird? —

Describe the bird's behavior (e.g. flying, feeding, or habits used in identifying):

Bird's odd jerky-jerky flight pattern with much fluttering first caught our attention. Occasionally the bird would fall as if shot by a gun or "stalling", and then pull out of it. Flight direction in general was distinctly "n" to "s" as if migrating.

Describe in detail the bird's relative size, overall shape, plumage and color pattern. Include details of bill, wing and tail shape. Give particular emphasis to marks you used to identify the bird. Reference to its resemblance to field guide descriptions and illustrations is not enough. Describe only what you actually observe in the field:

The bird was obviously a night hawk. It was a light buffy brown. Each wing was marked with a bold white slash about midway between the "elbow" and the tip of the 1st primary. The wing tips were distinctly rounded, making the wings overall appear short compared to common night hawks. The tail was notched and had a light band near, but not at, the tail tip. First primary was shorter than second. This helped provide the rounded, splayed look to the wing tip.

Of all marks, flight pattern was the most distinctive (difficult to describe this adequately).

Description (continued):

[Although unrelated, but perhaps worthy of mention, Kevin Cook of Fort Collins claims to have seen a lesser nighthawk at this same location in the late spring of 1993 or 1994.]

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery, (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration):

Silent

Describe the general and specific habitat in which you observed the bird:

Riparian corridor flanked by gravel ponds and flat terrain.

How did you eliminate similarly appearing species? Odd flight pattern, rounded wing tips & appearance of short wings, white wing slashes slightly further out toward wing tips, lighter coloration and broader tail band all were consistent with Lesser vs. Common. First primary was shorter than second - This is what made wing tip "round".

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species?

I have seen several Lesser Nighthawks in the Southwest US, one over the Clifton Sewer Ponds in '94 and one this Spring @ Two Buttes. I have seen thousands of Common Nighthawks. In the East I've seen chuckwills - widows, whip-poor-wills. List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: None

b) after observation: All the std references

This report was written from reports made during X, after observation X from memory
Date and time report was written:

Reporting observer: David Leatherman Signature: David Leatherman

Address: 612 Stover St #7 Ft Collins, CO 80524 970/416-0193 (H)

All reports will be maintained permanently at the address below:
Return to:

970/491-6303 (W)

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